

ORIGINAL ARTICLE

A thematic analysis of lived experiences of bullying among school going adolescents - Anthropological insights

KAWALJIT KAUR, GAYATHIRI PATHMANATHAN, BAHADUR SINGH, KEWAL KRISHAN

Department of Anthropology, Panjab University, Sector-14, Chandigarh, India

ABSTRACT

Background and aim: Bullying is a public health concern with social and psychological consequences.

In India, quantitative research on bullying prevalence has considerably grown, however, qualitative investigations remain limited. The present study explores the lived experiences of bullying among school going adolescents with a focus on the understanding of students about bullying, their responses towards bullying incidents, peer support, the role of parents' and school in bullying intervention.

Methods: The study presents the thematic analysis of open-ended responses collected from the school going adolescents of North India. For the main study, 976 subjects were recruited from six schools with an age range 12-18 years. The responses were thematically analysed using NVivo software.

Results: Verbal and physical bullying were the most reported forms of bullying with relational and sexual bullying also predominantly represented. The classroom and the playground were reported as the most likely places where bullying incidents occur. Friends and parents emerge as the primary interveners while teachers and school principal play peripheral role. Peers were reported the main perpetrators for the bullying incidents in school, however, a few instances of adult perpetration such as teacher and bus conductor were also reported. Retaliation was frequently cited as a motivation for bullying by the perpetrators.

Conclusions: The findings of present study highlight gap in the institutional response mechanism and significance of family and peer support. The findings also point towards the need of context specific antibullying programmes in Indian schools. The study contributes to the growing literature on school bullying in India and offers implications for policy making. (www.actabiomedica.it)

Key words: school bullying, cyberbullying, adolescence, perpetrator, retaliation, victim, behaviour



Received: 24 April 2026 | Accepted: 24 May 2026

Correspondence: Dr. Kewal Krishan, PhD, FRAI, Professor and former Chair, / Department of Anthropology, Panjab University, Sector-14, Chandigarh, India / E-mail: gargkk@yahoo.com, kewalkrishan@pu.ac.in

ORCID: 0000-0001-5321-0958

Introduction

Bullying in the school settings is one of the most studied issues that persistently remains unsolved. Bullying is prevalent worldwide, and it can occur in a variety of settings, such as home, school, workplace and community settings (1). Despite of its global prevalence, equivalent terms for bullying may not exist in some countries. Moreover, its definition may vary across cultures and languages. Therefore, comparing the information and prevalence of bullying across countries is cumbersome. Bullying has been predominantly investigated by psychological approach while cultural and social factors are taken into consideration only in a few studies.

Bullying cannot be reduced to an individual psychological failing because it is deeply embedded in the social structure of communities. The anthropological perspective helps us to understand that aggression is not a universal constant. Aggression is permitted or condemned depending on the norms of a given society (2). What counts as acceptable behavior in one cultural setting may not be permitted in another. Even the intensity of aggressive behavior in children depends upon their sociocultural environment (3). Adolescence is the transitional stage at which young people are gradually initiated into the adult social order by learning its unspoken rules, rehearsing its exclusions, and probing its boundaries. The school, in this sense, is not merely an institution of learning but a crucible of social formation. In the Indian context, this formation is further complicated by entrenched axes of inequality on the basis of skin colour, caste-linked surnames, religious identity, and gender. Young people quickly learn to read and respond to all these social markers. The school thus becomes a site where macro-level social hierarchies find expression in the micro-level texture of everyday interaction (4,5).

In India, most of the bullying research has relied on quantitative instruments to measure the prevalence and type of bullying that offer limited insight into the social context of these events. Open-ended responses collected from school going adolescents are especially valuable in the Indian context. Since bullying in India is not just a psychological issue but a social phenomenon where caste, religion, gender and socioeconomic

status play a major role. The present study addresses this gap by analysing open ended responses drawn from a structured bullying questionnaire administered to school going adolescents of North India. The objective of the study is to present a thematic analysis of the lived experiences of bullying among school going adolescents as perpetrators, as victims and as recipients of intervention.

Methodology

The present study used qualitative research design grounded in thematic analysis. The data were drawn from open ended responses within a structured questionnaire administered as a part of large doctoral research project. While the broader study employed a mixed methods design, the present paper focuses only qualitative data generated through open ended questions, showing participant centred exploration of bullying experiences that quantitative measures could not yield alone. The growing bullying literature reflects consensus that understanding the bullying as social phenomena requires its meaning, context and the subjective accounts those involved. While less rich conversationally than interviews, open ended questionnaires responses offer a feasible means of accessing the experience of large number of participants in school settings. The structured questionnaire used in this study was purpose-built for the Indian adolescent context. As no validated instrument adequately captures the sociocultural dimensions of bullying in India including caste, religion, and socioeconomic markers. While formal psychometric validation was beyond the scope of the present study, the content validity of instrument was established through this iterative development process.

The study sample comprised school-going adolescents from an urban educational setting in North India. Data were collected after obtaining written informed consent from parents and assent from the students of six public schools in Chandigarh. The participants were assured of the strict confidentiality of their responses at the time of recruitment, as part of the informed consent process approved by the institutional ethics committee. The sample consisted of 976

students studying in the 7th to 12th standards with an age range of 12-18 years. The sample consisted of 545 girls and 431 boys, with a mean age of girls (14.9) and boys (14.6). The study is guided by the five research questions shown in Table 1.

The questionnaire was administered in the classrooms. The students were free to respond in their own language (Hindi, Punjabi, English). Responses were translated into English and then imported into NVivo 14 and subjected to thematic coding using an interpretation-focused, data-driven strategy guided by Braun & Clarke (2006) (6) Please note that your references do not follow the journal's guidelines. According to our style, references should be numbered consecutively in the order in which they appear in the text Subsequently, the codes were then arranged into themes with similar codes grouped to form coherent themes. Thematic coding and translation of responses from Hindi and Punjabi into English were performed by the primary researcher, who is a native speaker of Punjabi and proficient in Hindi; the coding framework and emerging themes were reviewed and validated by the senior author.

Results and findings

The open-ended questions analysed in this paper were answered by varying numbers of participants. A total of 308 responses for all open-ended questions were recorded. 147 participants (males = 82, females = 65) responded to question about intervention following bullying victimisation; 73 participants (males = 38, females = 35) described their most recent victimisation incident; 41 participants (males = 20, females = 21)

reported additional forms of bullying they had experienced; and 37 participants (males = 24, females = 13) described a recent incident in which they had bullied someone. The gender balance across the responses reflects the mixed-gender composition of the schools involved. The analysis generated three overarching themes. These themes correspond to the content of the open-ended questions: forms and contexts of victimisation, and self-reported perpetration.

Victimisation is multi-form, contextually embedded, and extends beyond peers

The responses reveal a diversity of experiences of bullying among the participants. Total 73 respondents (male=38, female=35) answered to the second question. Some participants reported victimisation due to more than one kind of bullying, therefore those responses were coded twice or thrice as per the bullying category indicated. Although the third question was framed to explore any kind of bullying that occurs among school going adolescents and has not been covered in the bullying questionnaire employed for the study. This question was answered by 41 respondents (male=20, female=21). However no unique form of bullying has been reported in the responses. But the respondents just shared the incidents that are again covered under the four major categories of bullying- physical, verbal, sexual and relational.

Verbal bullying was the most frequently reported form of victimisation which includes verbal abuse in the form of jokes, abusive language, name-calling and teasing. Such experiences mostly include hurtful comments about name, parent's name, physical appearance, social status, caste, nationality and personal

Table 1: Open-ended questions used to elicit qualitative responses.

1.	What action did they take? (This question was a follow-up to 'Did they take any action after listening to you?', which was answered only to by those students who had disclosed the bullying incidents to someone whether a teacher, principal, friend, parent, relative, or any other person.)
2.	Can you recall the latest incident that happened to you? When did that happen? Where did that happen? Please write the details.
3.	If you have experienced any other form of bullying, please specify.
4.	Can you recall the latest incident when you bullied someone? When did that happen? Where did that happen? Please write the details.
5.	If you ever bullied someone by other means, please specify.

characteristics of a person. Teeth, skin colour, obesity, stature and hair were reported as the targeted physical attributes for name calling. Representative accounts illustrate the social dimensions of this form of bullying:

"People always say things about my religion, caste. Just because I belong to another country, they say things about my eyes, on my family." (17 years, female)

"Yesterday itself, when I came to school my classmates started calling me by names like 'jhaadu' because I have curly hair. In my previous school, I used to get bullied by teachers too." (16 years, female)"

Physical bullying was the second most reported form of victimisation in the form of being attacked, hit, pushed, or slapped by fellow students and hitting with objects. 16 incidents of physical bullying were reported. Being slapped is the most common form of physical bullying.

Relational bullying is reported by 11 participants and includes behaviors such as exclusion, rumour-spreading, ruining homework, stealing lunch box and humiliation. A response also indicates intimidation by teacher to get some unnecessary work done from the participant. Another response describes that the boys blackmail girls to make their videos go viral. It is to be noted that this act itself is not strictly cyberbullying but these forms of relational aggression enabled by digital access reflect evolution of bullying behavior from traditional forms. One account captures the sustained, multi-dimensional nature of relational bullying:

"In 6th grade, I had a very serious arguments with my friend. After that she and her other friend stated to bully me by calling names, ruining my homework, telling other students to not to talk to me, humiliating me in playground." (16 years, female)

Sexual bullying though reported by only six participants (five females, one male) produced the most severe accounts in dataset. Sexual harassment incidents, which included inappropriate touching, explicit sexual remarks and gestures were reported. One female participant experiences continuous sexual harassment by a senior male student that remains unresolved

despite one of their teacher's awareness. The most detailed account below illustrates the institutionally-ignored nature of peer sexual harassment:

"I was in 7th grade and the boy who sexually abused me was my senior, he was in 12th class... he started to abuse me sexually and there was a teacher who knew that boy was abusing me but he didn't take any action... I have cried a lot and spent my whole year doing this. After 7th, I decided to change my school and move on." (17 years, female)

A further account from a female respondent reveals an ongoing inappropriate touching by a public bus conductor. These accounts are not only significant for their severity but because they show the involvement of adult perpetrators such a teacher, a bus conductor and a stepfather in bullying victimisation. Despite the peers being predominant perpetrators, school bullying cannot be understood as a purely peer level phenomenon due to the presence of adult perpetrators. Only one response was obtained for cyberbullying that include receiving an obscene picture. Bullying incidents mostly take place within school settings, particularly within classrooms and playgrounds. Some responses reveal bullying taking place within the home involving family members, at public places like in buses, markets, or during commutes and tuition.

Informal networks dominate interventions

In this section, analysis of the interventions taken by those whom participants informed about bullying incidents is presented. First, it was inquired whether they had ever told anyone about their situation of being bullied with options such as teacher, principal, friend, parent, relative, or any other person. If they reported having told someone, they were then asked whether that person did anything after listening to them. Finally, an open-ended follow-up question asked participants to describe the nature of the action taken by the person they informed. A total of 147 participants (males=82, females=65) responded to these questions. The responses were categorized as teacher, principal, friend, parents, relative, any other person

and a miscellaneous category for cases where students had not specified any option.

Of the 147 responses, friends (n=53) and parents (n=52) were the most cited sources of intervention. Teachers were mentioned by 21 respondents and these interventions include scolding, physical punishment and calling up the parents of the bullies. Sometimes teachers take the matter to higher authorities such as school principal while in other cases they take minimal action. They also intervene by informing the parents of the victims, and also giving support to the victim. No instance of students directly seeking help from the school principal was reported. It is very rare that even parents/teachers approached the school principal and is reported hardly by 2-3 students. The intervention includes rustication that is specified in just one response. The following accounts illustrate the range of teacher responses:

"Informed to class teacher and teacher called her parents and gave her warning." / "The teacher hit the boys with a stick and forwarded the complaint to the principal." / "My teacher gave punishment to the bullies and they stopped it."

Peer intervention was the most diverse ranging from providing emotional support to victim, informing the adults to physical confrontation with the bully and act as mediators to resolve the conflict. One participant described the peer led resolution:

"We all gather at the spot to resort the thing we had between and come to an agreement we would not fight or this will go to the principal."

Parental responses were equally varied. Parents often took proactive measures to ensure the safety of child. The range of parental interventions varies from confronting the parents of bullies, discussing the matter with teachers, to giving mere emotional support and advice to their children. Sometimes parents directly confront the bullies to resolve the issue. They also provide advice to the children on tackling the situation by themselves. The most common action taken by parents is to contact school. In severe case, they take legal action. In one striking case parents relocated the child rather than addressing the bullying:

"They shifted me to a hostel but they did not take any actions against them. They just parted our ways."

Only 2 participants mentioned sibling interventions, one respondent mentioned tuition teacher and other mentioned counsellor, however no intervention have been reported by these two. No other responses were obtained for this category.

The absence of school counsellors can be noted from the participants' accounts of interventions. The findings of the present study point towards a significant institutional gap. When bullying occurs, the school going adolescents in this sample relied almost entirely on informal networks with schools playing minimal and inconsistent role.

Perpetration is predominantly reactive and morally contested

In the fourth question, the respondents were asked to write the latest incident when they bullied someone and where. Of the total 37 respondents who described bullying someone else, physical bullying was the most reported (n=15) followed by verbal bullying (n=7) and a single instance of relational bullying. It is to be noted that female participants accounted for nearly half of physical perpetration incidents. This finding differs from the typically reported gender pattern for physical aggression.

Another key finding was that approximately ten participants describe their aggression or bullying behavior as a response to prior provocation such as rumour spreading or verbal abuse directed at them or their family member. Actions taken in retaliation were indicated from 10 responses (male=8, female=2). However, it cannot be clear if these were the actions taken in defence for a single instance and fulfil criteria of bullying that is repetition of these actions.

This reactive perpetration suggests bully-victim overlap and adequacy of distinctions between perpetrators and victims in research and intervention designs. However, it should also be noted that repetition being one the definitional criteria of bullying could not be verified in these self-reports. Therefore, some incidents may constitute reactive aggression rather than bullying.

In the fifth question, participants were asked about other means of bullying perpetration. Total 10 response were obtained for this question by 8 males and 2 females. Although no unique means of perpetration were reported but an account was accompanied by moral reflection and regret.

"Just to agree with other people I bullied her calling her black. I regret about my behavior and I apologized her for being bully."

Such account suggest that empathy based and restorative approaches to intervention can be effective for students whose bullying is shaped by peer pressure or provocation rather than by aggressive dispositions.

Discussion

The present study provides a qualitative portrait of bullying experiences of school going adolescents in North India that resists reduction to individual psychology. The qualitative depth of this study distinguishes it from the existing literature. For instance, the prevalence studies can only reveal that appearance-based bullying exists however the qualitative data reveals what it sounds like. Four themes emerge from analysis of the data: the dominance of verbal bullying in victimisation, the role of friends and parents as primary intervention, the school as a permissive social space and majority of perpetration accounts framed as reactive.

The dominance of verbal bullying in present study is coherent with international literature (7,8). The prevalence of appearance-based bullying related to weight, height, skin colour, hair texture and dentition mirror findings from Indian studies. In Indian context, verbal bullying is intertwined with social identity of an individual such as their caste, religion, socioeconomic status and physical appearance suggesting that bullying is not interpersonal but a social phenomenon (9). Bullying on the basis of national origin was reported by one student in this study. It must be noted that these are not just characteristics but the social markers based on which Indian society distributes honour and stigma. The concept of symbolic violence given

by Pierre Bourdieu is applicable to this finding (10). Bourdieu's concept of habitus suggests that these dispositions are internalised through socialisation long before they are consciously enacted (11). Children arrive at school equipped with a grammar of social difference. They practice that grammar in the peer group that leads to further consolidation of the vocabulary. It reflects the transfer of the macro-level structures of Indian social inequality into the micro-level as peer interaction (4,5). The Indian education system benefits students who possess the cultural capital corresponding to upper-caste, middle-class habitus and marginalises those who do not (12). Bullying in this context is not incidental to schooling but one of its operative mechanisms.

The findings of present study extend the existing Indian literature. A systematic review of bullying studies in India has reported risk factors such as caste, religion, gender, colour, and socioeconomic status are specific to the Indian context (9). Another Indian study on bullying prevalence conducted in schools Bangalore found verbal bullying (55.17%) as well as verbal victimisation (65.75%) were the most prevalent reported forms (13). The present study extends these quantitative findings by providing participant-authored accounts. These accounts illuminate the content and social meaning of bullying.

Physical bullying is the second most reported form of bullying in this study. Boys with higher testosterone are more likely to be perceived as socially dominant by peers, independently of their aggression levels (14,15). In the present study, the finding that female participants accounted for nearly half of all self-reported physical perpetration is striking and departs from the gendered pattern typically reported in the literature (16) This reflects a distinctive feature of the cultural context where female physical assertiveness, typically suppressed by patriarchal gender norms, is expressed within the relative privacy of the peer group.

Relational bullying encompassing rumour spreading, blackmailing, stealing lunch box, ruining homework, coercive control, stalking and social exclusion on the basis of disability, personality and parental separation were reported in this study. An account of threatening to make personal videos go viral- points toward emergence of digitally-enabled relational aggression.

This represents an evolution of traditional relational bullying rather than cyberbullying. The coercive instrument is digital however the social context in which it operates remains the school. The global literature indicates that relational bullying shares the highest correlation with cyberbullying than any other traditional bullying form where perpetrators of relational aggression extend their tactics across digital platforms while maintaining the same interpersonal goals of social control and dominance (17).

The sexual bullying accounts in this study are the most sociologically and anthropologically significant data both in their severity and in the profile of their perpetrators. Five of the six sexual bullying accounts were provided by female participants. This finding is consistent with global patterns of gendered victimisation in school settings (18). Sexual harassment in schools can be understood as gender-based violence that functions to reinforce patriarchal power structures (19). In the Indian context, these dynamics are amplified by cultural norms around female modesty. In females, the association of sexual victimisation with family shame, victim blaming and the expectation to stay silent are the major obstacles that prevent disclosure (20-22). In the present study, a female participant endured a year of sexual harassment by a senior male student without any school response even after the teacher's awareness. She experienced the systematic operation of a patriarchal culture that prioritizes the social comfort of perpetrators over the safety of female victims. The research on child sexual abuse in India has documented that due to socio-cultural and familial factors, intra-institutional sexual abuse routinely goes unreported (23). Further, the bus conductor who repeatedly touched a female student on her commute extends the field of sexual victimisation beyond the school gate. This implicates a wider institutional network in the normalisation of female vulnerability.

Critically, perpetrators of sexual bullying in this study were not only peers. They included a senior student, a teacher who failed to act, a bus conductor, and a stepfather. This multi-perpetrator profile spans over peer, institutional, and domestic relationships. This finding is significant because it suggests that bullying among school going adolescents cannot be addressed only by peer-focused anti-bullying programmes.

It should be noted that a few students reported teacher intervention which ranged from reprimanding the bully, contacting parents to escalating incidents to school authorities. This suggests that teacher responsiveness is not entirely absent but inconsistent. It may reflect individual initiative rather than systemic support. In present study, hard to access principal, no functioning counsellor and inconsistent teacher response portray the near total institutional absence in bullying intervention. The teacher perpetrated abuse in several accounts such as academic threats, unresponsiveness in sexual abuse adds another concern. These behaviors of teachers make school environment unsafe for disclosure and resolution of bullying. Similar barriers to report bullying has been mentioned in existing literature (24,25). Therefore, imparting training to teachers in bullying recognition and response, developing accessible and anonymous mechanism for student reporting, and make school counsellor available are non-negotiable to mitigate school bullying.

Consequently, the burden of care falls entirely onto the informal networks of friendship and family. The role of friends and parents as the primary interveners highlights significance of informal social support networks in bullying management. Peer and parental support to deal with bullying is consistent with international literature (26). This finding aligns with another Chandigarh sample indicating that adults in schools rarely intervene to prevent bullying (27). However, in the present study, the variation in parental response from being assertive to passive advice, victim blaming suggests that parental interventions depend upon their awareness, cultural norms and practical capacity. These findings call for parent education programmes that not only raise awareness about bullying but equip parents with response strategies. Peer responses are the most diverse and most frequently cited. The most common response is friends who support victims by physically confronting bullies. It is to be noted that although the intention here is different but the supporters are also using the same logic as bullies that is power imbalance. This finding suggests that when schools fail to handle bullying both bullying and peer support use same methods.

Majority of self-reported perpetration accounts were framed as reactive. This finding emphasizes on the complexity of bully-victim dynamic. Reactive

perpetration suggests that many students in this sample who bully others do so in context of ongoing relational conflict. According to Bandura's social learning theory, adolescents perform by observing others so when they experience aggression and no authority intervenes, they learn that fighting back is an acceptable and understandable response. Bandura's idea of moral disengagement helps to explain how adolescents justify their actions (28). Students convince themselves that their aggression is reasonable as a response to rumours, insults, or being physically blocked. This allows them to act aggressively without feeling guilty (29).

Finally, some students showed regret and moral awareness such as one student apologised after passing a racial comment under peer pressure. This suggests that students are not morally indifferent. This finding has indirect implications for intervention design. Restorative approaches that address the relational contexts of conflict and impart skills for non-violent resolution may be more effective for these students rather than universal programmes.

Conclusion

In North India, bullying among school-going adolescents is far more complex than it appears on the surface. Verbal and physical bullying are reported as the most prevalent forms of bullying. Bullying in schools is deeply rooted in social inequalities created by caste, religion, gender, appearance, national origin and socioeconomic status. Adolescents rely on friends and family for support and intervention rather than school authorities. These findings highlight a significant institutional gap. The reactive nature of the reported perpetration reveals the complexity of bully-victim dynamics. The findings of present study call the need for context-sensitive and restorative approaches in mitigating bullying in Indian schools. Teacher training and accessible counselling services are the need of hour to create safer school environments.

Limitations and future directions

The current research has some limitations that must be noted. First, data was only collected in six selected

government schools in Chandigarh's urban settings, thus limiting the outreach capability of this research to private and rural schools. Second, open-ended responses were optional and submitted by only a small portion of the total research participants. This created a possible self-selection bias in the research, as it is likely that only those students who experienced recent or more extreme bullying chose to respond. Third, the written open response items are not as demonstrative as the interviews with participants or focus group discussions. Fourth, in the definition of bullying, one of the criteria is the repetitive nature of the action, and this could not be verified for some of the responses given by participants. This would, in some cases, be classed as reactive aggression, and not bullying. Fifth, due to the ethical constraints of the study, the research was unable to validate some of the accounts drawn by research participants, as in the case of adult perpetrators. Finally, due to the nature of the research being a descriptive one, the results were not shared with any of the parents or the school administrators.

Further research should focus on wider geographic and socioeconomic spectrums. Researchers should employ mixed methods that integrate the use of both surveys/questionnaires and in-depth interviews. Researchers should also adopt longitudinal studies that follow the same research participants in order to measure the effectiveness of the research interventions. Lastly, researchers should include the use of disclosure-management protocols as part of the ethical application, and also include referral pathways to child protection services.

Ethical approval: This study was approved by the Institutional Ethics Committee of Panjab University (PUIEC) wide letter no. PUIEC220128-II-065, dated: 7th March 2022.

Conflict of interest: The authors declare no competing and conflict of interests regarding this research work.

Authors contribution: K Kaur and KK conceived the idea of writing this paper. K Kaur collected the data from the school. K Kaur, GP, BS, and KK conducted the analysis. The data and the materials are available with one of the authors, K. Kaur. K Kaur, GP, BS, and KK wrote the initial draft of the manuscript. K Kaur, GP, BS, and KK wrote and approved the final version of the manuscript.

Declaration on the use of AI: None.

Consent for publication: While collecting the data for the study, the informed consent and signed consent form from each participant were obtained for publishing the information/images in an online open-access publication. Further, the present study has been conducted in accordance with the Declaration of Helsinki.

Acknowledgments: This study is a part of an on-going doctoral research by one of the authors (K Kaur) being conducted in the Department of Anthropology, Panjab University, Chandigarh. The study has been approved by Panjab University Institutional Ethical Committee vide letter no. EC-D-2203-125, Dated: 7th March 2022. K Kaur is thankful to the University Grant Commission for providing Senior Research Fellowship for the doctoral research. Authors are thankful to District Education officer for granting necessary approval to conduct research in schools. We extend our thanks to all the participants of the study. KK is supported by the UGC Centre of Advanced Study in Anthropology (CAS II), awarded to the Department of Anthropology, Panjab University, Chandigarh, India. The authors would also like to thank RUSA 2.0 grant awarded by the Ministry of Education, Government of India to the Panjab University, Chandigarh, India, for providing various research facilities.

Funding: None declared.

References

- Kupferman-Meik FE, Burris-Warmoth P, Rapaport S, Roychoudhury K, Javier RArt. Bullying in children and adolescents: a healthcare perspective. *J Soc Distress Homeless*. 2013 Nov;22(2):94–118. doi: 10.1179/1053078913Z.0000000006
- Cohen S. The development of aggression. *Rev Educ Res*. 1971;41(1):71–85. doi: 10.3102/00346543041001071
- Fraczek A. Violence and aggression in children and youth: A socio-psychological perspective. *European Review*. 1996;4(1):75–90. doi: 10.1002/(SICI)1234-981X(199601)4:1<75::AID-EURO110>3.0.CO;2-8
- Sreekanth Y. Bullying: An element accentuating social segregation. *Education 3-13*. 2009;37(3):233–45. doi: 10.1080/03004270802349463
- Campbell M, Kettle M, Sundaram S. Societal and Cultural Considerations in Understanding Peer Bullying in India. In: *Bullying, Cyberbullying and Student Well-Being in Schools: Comparing European, Australian and Indian Perspectives*. Cambridge University Press; 2018 May 17;26–44. doi:10.1017/9781316987384.003
- Braun V, Clarke V. Using thematic analysis in psychology. *Qual Res Psychol*. 2006 Jan 1;3(2):77–101. doi: 10.1191/1478088706qp063oa
- Man X, Liu J, Xue Z. Effects of Bullying Forms on Adolescent Mental Health and Protective Factors: A Global Cross-Regional Research Based on 65 Countries. *Int J Environ Res Public Health*. 2022 Feb 1;19(4). doi: 10.3390/ijerph19042374
- Han ZY, Ye ZY, Zhong BL. School bullying and mental health among adolescents: a narrative review. *Transl Pediatr*. 2025 Mar 31;14(3):463–72. doi: 10.21037/tp-2024-512
- Thakkar N, van Geel M, Vedder P. A Systematic Review of Bullying and Victimization Among Adolescents in India. *Int J. Bullying Prev*. 2021 Dec 1;3(4):253–69. doi: 10.1007/s42380-020-00081-4
- Bourdieu P, Passeron JC. *Reproduction in education, society and culture*. Sage; 1990.
- Bourdieu P. Outline of a Theory of Practice. In: *The new social theory reader*. 2020 Jul 24 (pp. 80-86). Routledge.
- Kumar B. Capital, habitus and symbolic violence: a Bourdieusian analysis of mode of reproductions in Indian schools. *Int J Soc Sci Hum Res*. 2025;8(9):7416–22. doi:10.47191/ijsshr/v8-i9-87
- Chhabria MS, Rao A, Rao C, Somashekar AR S. Prevalence and Forms of Bullying Perpetration and Victimization in Indian Adolescents. *Int J Med Public Health*. 2020 Nov 27;10(4):213–6. doi: 10.5530/ijmedph.2020.4.45
- Schaal B, Tremblay RE, Soussignan R, Susman EJ. Male testosterone linked to high social dominance but low physical aggression in early adolescence. *J Am Acad Child Adolesc Psychiatry*. 1996 Oct 1;35(10):1322–30. doi: 10.1097/00004583-199610000-00019
- Tremblay RE. Testosterone, physical aggression, dominance, and physical development in early adolescence. *Int J Behav Dev*. 1998 Dec 1;22(4):753–77. doi: 10.1080/016502598384153
- Silva MAI, Pereira B, Mendonça D, Nunes B, de Oliveira WA. The involvement of girls and boys with bullying: An analysis of gender differences. *Int J Environ Res Public Health*. 2013 Dec 5;10(12):6820–31. doi: 10.3390/ijerph10126820
- Johansson S, Englund G. Cyberbullying and its relationship with physical, verbal, and relational bullying: A structural equation modelling approach. *Educ Psychol (Lond)*. 2021 Mar 16;41(3):320–37. doi: 10.1080/01443410.2020.1769033
- UNESCO. *Global education monitoring report: gender report: building bridges for gender equality* [Internet]. Paris: UNESCO; 2019 Jan [cited 2026 Apr 28]. Available from: <https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000368753>
- Stein N. Sexual harassment in school: The public performance of gendered violence. *Harv Educ Rev*. 1995 Jul 1;65(2):145–63. doi: 10.17763/haer.65.2.7080h5t354300557
- Shabanipour M. Psycho-Social and Cultural Barriers in Disclosure of Victimization and Mental Health of the Sexually Abused Indian and Iranian Women. *Int J Humanit Cult Stud. (IJHCS)* ISSN. 2016 Feb;2356–5926.

21. Fleming K, Kruger LM. "She keeps his secrets": a gendered analysis of the impact of shame on the non-disclosure of sexual violence in one low-income South African community: original contributions. *African safety promotion*. 2013 Jan 1;11(2):107–24.
22. Zinzow HM, Thompson M. Barriers to reporting sexual victimization: Prevalence and correlates among undergraduate women. *J Aggress Maltreat Trauma*. 2011 Oct 1;20(7):711–25. doi: 10.1080/10926771.2011.613447
23. Carson DK, Foster JM, Chowdhury A. Sexual Abuse of Children and Youth in India An Anthropological Perspective. *Oriental Anthropol*. 2014 Dec;14(2):343–64. doi: 10.1177/0976343020140212
24. Nohilly M, Treacy M. Teachers' perceptions of enabling and hindering factors in child abuse disclosures. *Child Prot Pract*. 2024 Dec 1;3:100064. doi: 10.1016/j.chipro.2024.100064
25. Sharpe G. Barriers to Reporting Teachers' Abuse of Students. *Int J Learn Dev*. 2024 May 22;14(2):17. doi: 10.5296/ijld.v14i2.21924
26. Biswas T, Scott JG, Munir K, et al. Global variation in the prevalence of bullying victimisation amongst adolescents: Role of peer and parental supports. *EClinicalMedicine*. 2020 Mar 1;20. doi: 10.1016/j.eclinm.2020.100276
27. Rana M, Gupta M, Malhi P, Grover S, Kaur M. Prevalence and correlates of bullying perpetration and victimization among school-going adolescents in Chandigarh, North India. *Indian J Psychiatry*. 2020 Sep 1;62(5):531–9. doi: 10.4103/psychiatry.IndianJPsychiatry_444_19
28. Bandura A. Social cognitive theory: An Agentic Perspective. *Annu Rev Psychol*. 2000 Feb;52(1):1–26.
29. Burns S, Maycock B, Cross D, Brown G. 'Woodpushers are gay': the role of provocation in bullying. *Int J Ment Health Promot*. 2008 Nov;10(4):41–51. doi: 10.1080/14623730.2008.9721775

Copyright: The Author(s), 2026. Licensee Mattioli 1885, Fidenza, Italy. This is an open-access article distributed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution NonCommercial License (CC BY-NC-4.0).

Disclaimer/Publisher's Note: The statements, opinions and data contained in this article are solely those of the author(s) and contributor(s) and do not necessarily reflect those of their affiliated organizations, the publisher, the editors or the reviewers. The publisher and the editors disclaim any responsibility for injury to people or property resulting from any ideas, methods, instructions or products mentioned in the content. Any product that may be evaluated in this article, or claim made by its manufacturer, is not guaranteed or endorsed by the publisher.